

self-respect in a shared fidelity to my country," he would write in his memoir, *Faith of My Fathers*.

Today, four decades after that shock in Jakarta, Barack Obama himself is offering a treatment that will change the complexion of American politics. At 47, the first-time Senator from Illinois and the frontrunner in the presidential election, he is not just the Democratic candidate who has taken an unassailable lead in the opinion polls. He is the event that continues to shake America. He is the movement that aspires to bridge the racial divide. He is an idea that mobilises the disenchantment of eight years and inspires a generation craving for change—and for the mystery of the new. He is the latest concept in the politics of renewal in which the simplest of slogans, almost verging on banality—"change we can believe in"—sounds intimate and authentic. In political evolutions, there has hardly been a story of this magnitude in recent times. Brand Obama, whose exoticism is further accentuated by its sonorous pairing of vowels and consonants, has become America's most sensational export.

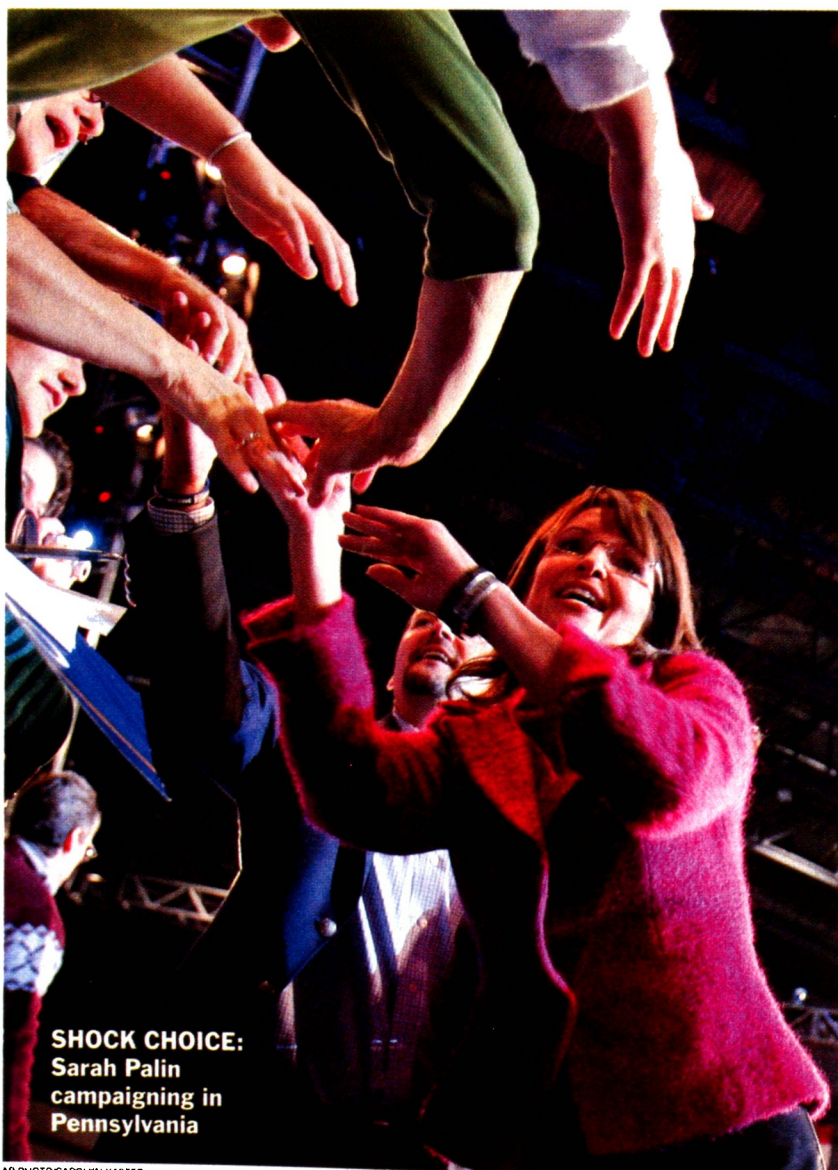
And John McCain, the prisoner of war from Hanoi, too, has come a long way—and is still fighting. His code of honour is still intact, and his courage has not diminished a bit amid the overwhelming bad news pouring in from all the battleground states, including the traditional red states. He is a maverick who ceases to be one when he chooses that word too often to describe himself on the stump. (The latest was when he appeared with his running mate Sarah Palin in the crucial Pennsylvania: "It's a lot of fun when two mavericks are together.") A straight-talking Republican at the Capitol Hill, he has never been a favourite of the Conservative establishment. In the true tradition of the soldier-politician, it has always been America First for him—and still it is. At the campaign rallies, this war-scarred veteran is always in the backdrop of those two words, for no "change" can be at the cost of the homeland for which this 72-year-old man has suffered and sacrificed so much. He is fighting the last battle of his life, in a place that increasingly looks more treacherous than the Vietnam of the Sixties.

The battle, in its final stage, is a lot more than a clash of two exceptional biographies in which merge all the personal mythologies that make

the so-called American Dream an enduring catch phrase in the glossary of human possibilities. Though it's biography that makes this election a history junkie's delight. So, if it's Obama, 1600 Pennsylvania Avenue will have its first African-American president. And if the McCain ticket wins, America will have its first woman vice-president (and the moose of Alaska will live longer.) The candidates themselves have marketed their life stories as a text inseparable from national destiny. Here goes Obama in his usual lyrical flourish: "Hope... Hope... is what led me here today—with a father from Kenya; a mother from Kansas; and a story that could only happen in the United States of America. Hope is the bedrock of this nation; the belief that our destiny will not be written for us, but by us; by all those men and women



The Palin MYSTIQUE has worn off. She is a mascot of Conservative values only for the core of GOP.



SHOCK CHOICE:
Sarah Palin
campaigning in
Pennsylvania

AP PHOTO/CAROLYN KASTER